Coaching Codex



COACHING CODEX · GUIDE 11 · AI SPREADSHEETS & DATA

AI Spreadsheets for Non-Techies: Formulas, Clean-Up & Reports

Stop googling Excel formulas. Ask in plain English, clean a messy customer list, and build a simple monthly report you can check.

10
formulas explained in plain words

Clean
duplicates, names and dates

1
simple monthly report you check

START HERE

Stop googling formulas. Ask in plain English.

Excel and Google Sheets already sit on most business desks. The hard part is remembering which formula does what, cleaning a messy list, and turning rows into a report you trust. AI can draft formulas and clean-up steps in plain words. You still check every number against your sheet before you use it.

10
Formulas
The ones most small businesses actually use, explained without jargon.

Clean
Lists
Duplicates, names and dates fixed with copy-paste prompts.

1
Report
A simple monthly summary you can build and verify in under an hour.

What's inside

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EXCEL OR GOOGLE SHEETS?

The prompts in this guide work for both. Tell the AI which one you use. Formula names are often the same; a few differ. Always paste the suggested formula into a spare cell first and check it against a row you already know.

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SECTION 01 · THE BASICS

What AI can (and can't) do with spreadsheets

AI is strong at explaining formulas, drafting clean-up steps and summarizing patterns you describe. It is weak at inventing your real totals. Never let it guess numbers you did not provide.

Great at	Be careful with
Writing a formula from a plain-English goal	Inventing sales totals or customer counts
Explaining what a formula does, step by step	Assuming your column letters without checking
Suggesting clean-up steps for duplicates and dates	Claiming a sheet is 'error-free' without your check
Turning a description of columns into a report layout	Prices, tax rates or dates you never confirmed
Rewriting a messy header row into clear labels	Pasting real customer emails or phone numbers into a free AI chat

The one-line rule

AI drafts the formula. You paste it into a test cell and check against a known row. Treat every answer like advice from a helpful intern: useful, then verified.

PROMPT · TEST HONESTY ON A FORMULA

I use [EXCEL / GOOGLE SHEETS]. My sheet has columns [A=DATE, B=CUSTOMER, C=AMOUNT in USD].
I want a formula that [GOAL IN PLAIN ENGLISH].
Give me the formula, explain each part in one short line, and list what I should double-check on my own sheet.

EXERCISE 1 · YOUR THREE MESSIEST SHEETS (3 MINUTES)

Name the three spreadsheets that slow you down most (for example: customer list, sales log, invoice tracker). You'll use one of them in later exercises.

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SECTION 02 · ASK CLEARLY

Ask for formulas in plain language

The AI cannot see your screen. Describe the sheet the way you would to a new hire: which columns, what each holds, and what result you want in which cell.

1. Say which tool: Excel or Google Sheets.
2. List the columns you care about (letter + what is in it).
3. State the goal in one sentence ("sum March sales", "flag duplicates").
4. Ask for the formula, a plain-English explanation, and what to check.
5. Paste into a spare cell first. Compare with a row you already know.

PROMPT · FORMULA FROM A PLAIN GOAL

I use [EXCEL / GOOGLE SHEETS].
Columns: [A = Date, B = Product, C = Qty, D = Unit price USD, E = blank for total].
Goal: in column E, multiply Qty by Unit price for each row.
Give me the formula for row 2, how to fill it down, and one way to check the first three rows against a hand calculation.

PROMPT · EXPLAIN A FORMULA I FOUND

Explain this formula in plain English, one short line per part:
[PASTE FORMULA]
My columns are: [DESCRIBE]. Tell me what could go wrong if a cell is blank or text.

SPARE-CELL HABIT

Never overwrite a working column on the first try. Add a helper column, paste the AI formula there, spot-check five rows, then decide whether to keep it.

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SECTION 03 · THE USEFUL TEN

Ten formulas most small businesses need

You do not need hundreds of functions. These ten cover totals, averages, lookups, dates and clean text for most owner-run sheets. Names below are common in Excel and Google Sheets; check your version if one fails.

Goal	Often use	Ask AI like this
Add a column	SUM	"Sum all amounts in column D"
Average	AVERAGE	"Average the scores in column C, ignore blanks"
Count filled rows	COUNTA	"Count how many customer names are in column B"
Count if matches	COUNTIF	"Count rows where Status is Paid"
Sum if matches	SUMIF / SUMIFS	"Sum Amount where Month is March"
Look up a value	XLOOKUP or VLOOKUP	"Find the price for this product code"
Today's date	TODAY	"Show today's date in a cell"
Days between	DATEDIF / DAYS	"Days between Order date and Paid date"
Clean spaces	TRIM	"Remove extra spaces from names"
Join text	CONCAT / &	"Combine first and last name with a space"

PROMPT · PICK THE RIGHT FORMULA

I use [EXCEL / GOOGLE SHEETS]. My goal: [GOAL IN PLAIN ENGLISH].
Columns: [LIST].
Suggest the simplest formula that fits. If two options exist, pick the one that is easier for a beginner and say why.
Do not invent sample numbers.

EXERCISE 2 · CIRCLE WHAT YOU NEED

Circle three goals from the table you will use this month. Write the sheet name beside each.

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SECTION 04 · CLEAN-UP

Clean duplicates, names and dates

Messy lists waste hours: the same customer twice, names in different cases, dates that refuse to sort. AI can suggest formulas and step-by-step clean-up. You still decide what to delete.

1. **Duplicates:** ask for a formula or filter that flags rows with the same email or phone (use anonymized sample rows in the chat).
2. **Names:** TRIM extra spaces; consistent Title Case; split or join first and last name only when you need it.
3. **Dates:** make one format (for example YYYY-MM-DD); fix text-looking dates before you chart or sort.
4. **Headers:** one clear header row; no merged cells in the data block you will filter.

PROMPT · FLAG DUPLICATES

I use [EXCEL / GOOGLE SHEETS]. Columns: [A=Name, B=Email, C=Last order date].
I want a helper column that shows DUPLICATE if the email in that row already appeared above, else OK.
Give the formula for row 2 and how to fill down. Do not invent emails. Explain how I should decide which row to keep.

PROMPT · FIX NAMES AND DATES

I use [EXCEL / GOOGLE SHEETS]. Sample rows (fictional, no real people):
[PASTE 3–5 SAMPLE ROWS WITH HEADERS]
Suggest formulas or steps to: trim spaces in names, make names consistent case, and turn date text into real dates in [FORMAT]. List each step in order. Ask me if a column meaning is unclear.

BEFORE YOU PASTE A CUSTOMER LIST

Do **not** paste real customer emails, phone numbers, addresses or card details into a free or personal AI chat. Use a few fictional or heavily anonymized sample rows (replace names with A, B, C and change digits). Prefer a business plan your company has approved if you must discuss real structure.

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SECTION 05 · MONTHLY REPORT

Build a simple monthly report

A useful monthly report for a small business is short: revenue, order count, top products or services, and one note on what changed. AI can propose the layout and the formulas. You fill it from your real sheet.

1 · CHOOSE COLUMNS
Date, amount, product/service, status

▶

2 · FILTER THE MONTH
One month only, confirmed dates

▶

3 · TOTALS & COUNTS
SUM / COUNTIF you checked

▶

4 · ONE INSIGHT LINE
What changed vs last month (your words)

PROMPT · MONTHLY REPORT LAYOUT

I run [TYPE OF BUSINESS] and track sales in [EXCEL / GOOGLE SHEETS].
Columns: [LIST WITH LETTERS].
I need a one-page monthly report for [MONTH YEAR] with: total revenue in USD, number of paid orders, average order value, and a short note field.
Propose a simple layout (which cells hold which formula). Use only the columns I listed. Do not invent sample totals. Ask if anything essential is missing.

PROMPT · SUMMARIZE PATTERNS (NO INVENTED NUMBERS)

Here are confirmed monthly totals from my records (USD):
[PASTE ONLY NUMBERS YOU VERIFIED]
Write 3 short bullet insights a busy owner can read in 30 seconds. Do not add any figure I did not provide. If a comparison needs a missing month, say so.

EXERCISE 3 · YOUR REPORT COLUMNS

Write the four columns your monthly report will use, and the month you will build first.

Columns:

First month:

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SECTION 06 · VERIFY

Check every number before you trust it

A polished formula can still point at the wrong range. Build a five-minute check into every sheet change.

- [ ] I tested the formula on a row whose answer I already know by hand
- [ ] The range covers the right rows (no extra blank totals, no missed last row)
- [ ] Currency is USD (or the currency I intended) and decimals look right
- [ ] Filters or month criteria match the dates on the sheet
- [ ] I did not overwrite the only copy of raw data

PROMPT · CHECK MY TOTALS

I use [EXCEL / GOOGLE SHEETS]. My total formula is: [PASTE FORMULA].
Columns and ranges: [DESCRIBE].
A hand total of the first 5 data rows is [AMOUNT USD].
Tell me how to verify the full column total without inventing numbers. List 3 common mistakes for this kind of formula.

Check	Pass?	Note
Spare-cell test vs known row		
Range includes last data row		
Month / status filter correct		
Backup copy of raw sheet saved		

KEEP A RAW TAB

Keep an untouched "Raw" tab or a dated copy before big clean-ups. If a formula goes wrong, you still have the original numbers.

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SECTION 07 · PRIVACY

Privacy and safe paste rules

Spreadsheets often hold customer names, emails and payment notes. Treat AI chats like a public whiteboard unless your company has approved a business plan with clearer controls.

- Anonymize: replace real names with Customer A/B/C; change or remove emails and phones
- Paste structure, not secrets: column headers and a few fake sample rows are enough for formula help
- No passwords, card numbers, ID numbers or full bank details — ever
- Prefer business or team plans when staff must discuss real operational data your policy allows
- Delete sensitive chats when you are done; review memory settings if your assistant has them

PROMPT · ANONYMIZE BEFORE ASKING

I will paste a small sample from a spreadsheet. Replace any personal names, emails, phones and addresses with placeholders like [NAME], [EMAIL], [PHONE]. Keep column headers and numeric patterns. Return only the anonymized sample, nothing else.

Sample:
[PASTE]

GDPR-SENSIBLE HABIT

If you serve customers in the UK or EU, minimize personal data in any external tool. When in doubt, describe the sheet structure without pasting real people. This guide is general information, not legal advice.

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SECTION 08 · HABIT

Your 7-day spreadsheet habit plan

One clean list and one monthly report beat a dozen half-finished sheets. Use this week to lock the habit.

Day	Action	Time (est.)	Done
1	Pick one messy sheet; save a Raw copy	10 min	
2	Ask AI for 2 formulas you need; test in spare cells	20 min	
3	Flag duplicates on an anonymized sample; apply carefully	25 min	
4	Fix names/dates on a helper column; spot-check 10 rows	20 min	
5	Build the monthly report layout for one month	25 min	
6	Fill totals from your real sheet; run the verify checklist	20 min	
7	Save your 3 best prompts; note what still confuses you	10 min	

Times are rough estimates and vary by sheet size.

PROMPT · WEEKLY REVIEW

This week I used AI on spreadsheets for: [TASKS].
What worked: [WINS]. What didn't: [PROBLEMS].
Suggest 3 clearer prompts for next week and rewrite my best formula prompt so a beginner could reuse it. Do not invent any of my business numbers.

Safety checklist

- [ ] I checked formulas against known rows before trusting totals
- [ ] No real customer personal data in a personal AI account
- [ ] I still have a Raw copy of the sheet I cleaned

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FIRST WIN · FICTIONAL EXAMPLE

Your first win, start to finish

Walk through one formula request for a made-up bakery in Austin. Nothing here is a real business or real customers.

Example input	Value
Tool	Google Sheets
Columns	A=Date, B=Item, C=Qty, D=Unit price USD, E=blank for line total
Goal	Line total = Qty × Unit price; then a column sum for March
Known check	Row 2: Qty 3 × USD 4.50 = USD 13.50

EXAMPLE COMPLETED PROMPT

I use Google Sheets.
Columns: A=Date, B=Item, C=Qty, D=Unit price USD, E=blank for line total.
Goal: in E2, multiply Qty by Unit price; fill down. Then give a SUM for column E for rows that fall in March (dates in column A).
Known check: row 2 should be 3 × 4.50 = 13.50 USD.
Give formulas, explain each part in one short line, and tell me how to verify against the known row. Use only these facts. Do not invent sales totals. If an essential fact is missing, ask me before drafting.

Copy it, open your AI assistant (ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini or Copilot), paste and send. Then compare what you get with this:

ILLUSTRATIVE ANSWER, NOT A LIVE AI RESULT

In E2 use =C2*D2 and fill down. For a March total, one simple approach is =SUMIF(A:A,">="&DATE(2026,3,1),E:E)-SUMIF(A:A,">="&DATE(2026,4,1),E:E) (adjust year to match your sheet), or filter March then SUM the visible cells. Check: E2 must show 13.50 before you trust any monthly sum.

Checks before use

- [ ] E2 equals the known hand total (USD 13.50).
- [ ] The monthly SUM only includes March dates on your sheet.
- [ ] No sales total was invented beyond the formulas.
- [ ] A human compared three rows before using the report.

USE IT

Paste the checked formula into a spare column on your own sheet. The webpage does not change your file.

GUIDED TASK

Get a spreadsheet formula in plain language

When to use it: You know the result you want but not which formula to type. **Prepare:** Which tool you use (Excel or Google Sheets); Column letters and what each holds; One known row you can check by hand.

Question	Example answer
Which spreadsheet tool?	Google Sheets
List your columns (letter = meaning).	A=Date, B=Item, C=Qty, D=Unit price USD, E=line total
What should the formula do, in one sentence?	Multiply Qty by Unit price in each row, then sum March totals
One known check (a row you can calculate by hand).	Row 2: 3 × 4.50 = 13.50 USD
Describe your business in one sentence.	A neighborhood bakery in Austin

PROMPT TEMPLATE

I use [EXCEL OR GOOGLE SHEETS].
About us: [ABOUT YOUR BUSINESS]
Columns: [COLUMNS]
Goal: [GOAL IN PLAIN ENGLISH]
Known check: [KNOWN CHECK]
Give the formula(s), explain each part in one short line, and tell me how to verify against the known check. Use only these facts. Do not invent totals. If an essential fact is missing, ask me before drafting.

ILLUSTRATIVE ANSWER, NOT A LIVE AI RESULT

E2: =C2*D2 (fill down). March total: filter March dates or use SUMIF on column A, summing E. Verify E2 shows 13.50 before trusting the month sum.

Checks before use

- [ ] The known row matches your hand calculation.
- [ ] Column letters in the formula match your sheet.
- [ ] No total was invented beyond the formulas.
- [ ] You tested in a spare cell first.

Repairs

If...	Send this
Wrong column letter	"Replace every reference to column [OLD] with [NEW]. Change nothing else."
Invented total	"Remove any sample totals you invented. Keep only formulas and the known check I gave."
Too complex	"Suggest the simplest beginner formula that meets the same goal. Explain in shorter lines."

Next action: Paste into a spare column, check three rows, then keep or discard.

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GUIDED TASK

Clean duplicates, names or dates

When to use it: Your list has repeats, messy names or dates that will not sort. **Prepare:** A few anonymized sample rows (no real emails or phones); Which problem to fix first: duplicates, names or dates.

Question	Example answer
Which spreadsheet tool?	Excel
What do you need to clean first?	Flag duplicate emails; keep the newest Last order date
Paste 3–5 fictional or anonymized sample rows with headers.	Name,Email,Last order Alex A,a@example.com,2026-03-02 Alex A,a@example.com,2026-01-10 Blair B,b@example.com,2026-03-15
Describe your business in one sentence.	A plumbing company in Ohio

PROMPT TEMPLATE

I use [EXCEL OR GOOGLE SHEETS].
About us: [ABOUT YOUR BUSINESS]
Clean-up goal: [CLEAN-UP GOAL]
Sample rows (fictional or anonymized):
[ANONYMIZED SAMPLE ROWS]
Suggest formulas or clear steps in order. Explain how I decide which duplicate row to keep. Use only this sample. Do not invent extra customers. If a column meaning is unclear, ask me before drafting.

ILLUSTRATIVE ANSWER, NOT A LIVE AI RESULT

Add a helper column that marks DUPLICATE when the email already appeared above. Sort or filter by email and Last order; keep the row with the newest date; delete or archive older duplicates only after you confirm.

Checks before use

- [ ] Sample rows contain no real personal contact details.
- [ ] The flag or filter matches your duplicate rule.
- [ ] You decide which row to keep — the AI does not delete for you.
- [ ] You still have a Raw copy of the sheet.

Repairs

If...	Send this
Assumed a column meaning	“Replace this assumption with: [FACT]. Change nothing else.”
Told me to delete without a rule	“Do not delete rows. Only flag duplicates. I will choose which to keep using: [RULE].”
Used real-looking personal data	“Replace every email and phone with placeholders like [EMAIL] and [PHONE].”

Next action: Apply the steps on a copy of your sheet, spot-check ten rows, then update the main list.

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GUIDED TASK

Build a simple monthly report

When to use it: You want a one-page month summary from a sales or jobs sheet. **Prepare:** Confirmed column list; Which month and year; Only totals you are ready to calculate yourself.

Question	Example answer
Which spreadsheet tool?	Google Sheets
List the columns your report will use.	A=Date, B=Service, C=Status, D=Amount USD
Which month and year?	March 2026
Which totals do you need on the page?	Total paid revenue USD, count of Paid rows, average order value
Describe your business in one sentence.	A dental clinic in Manchester

PROMPT TEMPLATE

I use [EXCEL OR GOOGLE SHEETS].
About us: [ABOUT YOUR BUSINESS]
Columns: [COLUMNS]
Month: [MONTH YEAR]
Metrics I need: [METRICS]
Propose a simple one-page layout and the formulas for each metric. Use only the columns I listed. Do not invent sample totals. Ask me if Status values or date formats are unclear. End by telling me how to verify each figure against the sheet.

ILLUSTRATIVE ANSWER, NOT A LIVE AI RESULT

Layout: title March 2026; cell for SUMIF Status=Paid on Amount; COUNTIF Status=Paid; average = paid total / paid count. Verify by filtering March + Paid and comparing the status bar sum to your formula cells.

Checks before use

- [ ] Every formula points at columns you actually have.
- [ ] No revenue figure was invented in the answer.
- [ ] Month filter matches your date column.
- [ ] You compared formula results to a filtered hand check.

Repairs

If...	Send this
Invented a revenue number	“Remove every sample total. Keep only layout and formulas. I will fill numbers from my sheet.”
Wrong status value	“Replace this assumption with the following confirmed fact: [FACT]. Change nothing else.”
Too many charts	“Simplify to three metric cells and one notes line. No charts.”

Next action: Build the layout on a new tab, fill from your real sheet, and run your verify checklist.

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WHAT'S NEXT

Formulas you understand. Lists you trust. Reports you checked.

Plain-English prompts, a clean customer list, and a monthly report built from numbers you verified: that is spreadsheets without the dread.

50 Copy-Paste AI Prompts for Small Business Owners

Fifty ready prompts for marketing, sales, service, admin and planning.

Automate Your Inbox and Customer Replies with AI

Turn cleaned customer lists into clearer follow-ups.

Custom AI Assistants for Your Business: Build Your First GPT, Gem or Project

Save your spreadsheet prompts as a reusable assistant.

AI Sales Emails That Get Replies: 25 Templates & Prompts

Use clean data to personalize outreach without inventing facts.

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